noting that Beijing might hesitate because any rapprochement with the US would "completely destroy the ideological claim and pretentions of China." There might be normalization, but he did not think that it would necessarily mean a Sino-US condominium against the Soviet Union or India. The foreign minister, however, agreed with another senior bureaucrat who said that any rapprochement would have "serious repercussions" in Asia and that India had "to carefully watch trends in this regard."[164]

Losing Interest

The US, on its part, was watching India less and less. For Johnson, whose focus remained on Vietnam, India was not being helpful and thus was becoming less critical for the US. Furthermore, by summer/autumn 1967, the country looked like it would at least not fall. Thus, over the last year or so of his administration, India slipped down the priority list. Disillusionment started leading to disinterest and disengagement.

With congressional approval and a World Bank assessment that India was keeping up its end of the bargain on reforms, the administration agreed to multilateral economic and food assistance plans in spring 1967.[165] But as Johnson considered Rostow's recommendation for additional food aid in August, his desire for disengagement was evident. He called for "someone to argue the other side please."[166] He subsequently asserted that "it would appeal to him if some other nation would recognize their responsibilities in this nation, even the Russians."[167] By summer 1968, Congress would be appropriating fewer funds for India than it had for about a decade.[168]

There were other signs of the American desire to disengage more generally. The administration outlined a new South Asia military supply policy, which restarted a program to train some Indian and Pakistani officers, allowed limited credit sales, and opened up on a case-by-case basis the sales of spare parts for US-supplied equipment. Washington would also finish funding the radar system on the Sino-Indian border, because it directly "contribute[d] to US security interests." But it would withdraw the US military advisory groups in India and Pakistan, cease sales of lethal equipment, and require approval of third-country sales of equipment covered by US controls. Overall, Rusk said, "We are in fact reverting to a military relationship with both countries similar to the one we had in the